"But the current central leadership has taken it up a notch, with governors like Ravi stretching constitutional limits at every level," says political commentator N. Sathia Moorthy.

The governor's response on the universities bills typifies this. Ravi has denied assent to bills that sought to replace the governor with the chief minister as chancellor of state universities in Tamil Nadu. He has also gone on to appoint University Grants Commission nominees for panels to select vice-chancellors. And this when the larger matter of the governor's continuance as chancellor is sub judice.

Laws amended and passed in states like Gujarat have the CM as the chancellor. Thus, for a governor or even the President to deny such powers to other state assemblies could be regarded as ipso facto unfair and politically motivated, say experts. "A political war is being fought under constitutional cover. The Centre must not seek to bend constitutional provisions for cheap political ends, which in the past have proved to be infructuous in 'Dravidian' Tamil Nadu. It irritates the people, as there is this view that the state's pride is being hurt by outsiders who do not know the culture of their lands," adds Moorthy.

Governments in several non–BJP ruled states have complained about governors delaying assent or indefinitely sitting on bills. Some of these instances from Punjab, Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Kerala have also seen interventions by the Supreme Court, unfailingly urging governors to not stall normal governmental processes.

On February 6, Kerala pushed for an early hearing in the SC of its writ petition arguing the same, saying governors have launched an "endemic" on governance by stalling bills passed by state assemblies. The ongoing examination by the apex court of these issues is expected to clarify the limits of the governor's discretion and could have far-reaching implications for Centre-state relations and the role of this constitutional office. ■

RANVEER ALLAHBADIA ROW

A JOKE GOES TOO FAR

By Suhani Singh and Kaushik Deka

"Anything we say as social media influencers can be used against us." This cautionary warning from YouTuber Ranveer Allahbadia in his 2020 video 'Dear Angered Indians' now feels eerily prophetic. The popular, 31-year-old podcaster, who goes by the moniker BeerBiceps, finds himself at the centre of a storm after making a controversial remark on comedian Samay Raina's show *India's Got Latent*, one that has ignited a national debate on obscenity. What began as an offhand joke is now the test-case for digital regulation and the limits of free speech.

The backlash was swift. Multiple FIRs were lodged against Allahbadia and others on the show in Maharashtra, Assam and Rajasthan. Seeking relief, he approached the Supreme Court, which, on February 18, rebuked him sharply. A bench comprising Justices Surya Kant and N. Kotiswar Singh called his remarks "disgusting", "filthy", and reflective of a "perverted mind". Though granting Allahbadia protection from arrest and any new FIR, they imposed stringent conditions on him:

- He must surrender his passport at the Thane police station and cannot leave the country without prior court approval
- He must fully cooperate with the police investigation
- He is barred from airing any new content on YouTube or any other platform until further orders.

It's a spectacular fall for one of the most sought-after digital creators. The son of Mumbai-based doctors, he veered away from an expected engineering career to launch 'BeerBiceps' in 2015, a YouTube channel initially focused on fitness and wellness. By 2019, recognising a gap in India's podcasting market, he rebranded himself into a widely followed interviewer, hosting Union ministers and other top politicians, celebrities and thought leaders on *The Ranveer Show* (*TRS*). His ability to engage guests in a non-confrontational manner made his podcast a hit, topping Spotify charts, but also inviting accusations of being a "sellout". Beyond content creation, Allahbadia founded Monk Entertainment, a talent management firm, in 2017 and launched a mental fitness app and other ventures that would establish him as an entrepreneur. A former employee, who worked closely with him on *TRS*, describes him as extremely "enterprising", "spiritual", "empathetic" and also "socially awkward". In March 2024, Allahbadia shared the stage with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who presented him the 'Disruptor of the Year' award at the inaugural National Creators Awards. Today, the demand for that award to be rescinded is only growing louder.

WHAT BEGAN AS AN OFFHAND JOKE ON A YOUTUBE SHOW HAS SPIRALLED INTO A NATIONAL DEBATE ON OBSCENITY, DIGITAL REGULATION AND THE LIMITS OF FREE SPEECH

In the Supreme Court, Allahbadia's legal team, led by advocate Abhinav Chandrachud, argued that while his remarks might be distasteful, they do not necessarily amount to obscenity. Legal interpretations of obscenity have evolved over time—from